Fall Protection Inspection (29 CFR 1926.501)

A suggested site walk-round (1926.501 sets no inspection frequency): use it before work at height and after changes to edges, openings, roofs or hoisting.

OSHA 29 CFR 1926.501

DATE	SHIFT
INSPECTOR	AREA / EQUIPMENT ID

Before you start

1. Mark every item OK, Defect or N/A. Use N/A only where that work or feature is not on site.
2. For any Defect, stop the exposed work at that spot until protection is in place, then record what was fixed and when.
3. The equipment manufacturer's instructions and your site rules may add checks to this list.

Legal basis: 29 CFR 1926.501: Duty to have fall protection (Part 1926 Subpart M: Fall Protection) Source: eCFR, Title 29, text as of 2026-11-09
Online version and sources: https://safetyindex.blog/us/standards/1926-501-duty-have-fall-protection

SECTION A | Surfaces, edges and openings

No.	Check item	What to look for	OK	Defect	N/A	Notes
1	Systems meet § 1926.502 Ref. 1926.501(a)(1)	Each guardrail, net and fall arrest system in use has been checked against the criteria in § 1926.502.	☐	☐	☐	
2	Surface strength Ref. 1926.501(a)(2)	The employer has determined that the surface can support employees safely, and no one is working on a surface that has not been confirmed.	☐	☐	☐	
3	Unprotected sides and edges Ref. 1926.501(b)(1)	Every side or edge 6 ft (1.8 m) or more above a lower level has a guardrail, a safety net, or workers tied off with personal fall arrest.	☐	☐	☐	
4	Ramps, runways and walkways Ref. 1926.501(b)(6)	Guardrail systems are in place wherever a walkway user could fall 6 ft or more to a lower level.	☐	☐	☐	
5	Wall openings Ref. 1926.501(b)(14)	Openings with an outside bottom edge at least 6 ft above a lower level and an inside bottom edge under 39 in (1.0 m) above the floor have a guardrail, a net, or workers using fall arrest.	☐	☐	☐	
6	Hoist areas Ref. 1926.501(b)(3)	Hoist area edges with a drop of 6 ft or more have guardrails, or workers there are using personal fall arrest.	☐	☐	☐	
7	Leaning out at hoist openings Ref. 1926.501(b)(3)	Anyone leaning through or out over an access opening where the guardrail, chain or gate has been removed is wearing personal fall arrest.	☐	☐	☐	
8	Other elevated surfaces Ref. 1926.501(b)(15)	Any surface 6 ft or higher that is not covered by another paragraph has a guardrail, net or personal fall arrest system.	☐	☐	☐	

General guidance only, not legal advice. Check the current regulation and your employer's procedures.

SECTION B | Holes, excavations and dangerous equipment						
No.	**Check item**	**What to look for**	**OK**	**Defect**	**N/A**	**Notes**
9	Holes and skylights (falls through) Ref. 1926.501(b)(4)(i)	Holes and skylights more than 6 ft above a lower level have covers or guardrails around them, or workers nearby are using personal fall arrest.	☐	☐	☐	
10	Holes (trips and steps) Ref. 1926.501(b)(4)(ii)	Covers are in place over holes and skylights where someone could trip in or step into or through them.	☐	☐	☐	
11	Holes (falling objects) Ref. 1926.501(b)(4)(iii)	Covers are in place over holes and skylights where objects could fall through onto employees.	☐	☐	☐	
12	Hidden excavation edges Ref. 1926.501(b)(7)(i)	Excavations at least 6 ft deep that are hidden by plants or another visual barrier have guardrails, fences or barricades at the edge.	☐	☐	☐	
13	Wells, pits and shafts Ref. 1926.501(b)(7)(ii)	Wells, pits, shafts and similar excavations 6 ft or more deep have guardrails, fences, barricades or covers.	☐	☐	☐	
14	Dangerous equipment (under 6 ft) Ref. 1926.501(b)(8)(i)	Where workers are less than 6 ft above dangerous equipment, guardrails or equipment guards stop them from falling into or onto it.	☐	☐	☐	
15	Dangerous equipment (6 ft or more) Ref. 1926.501(b)(8)(ii)	Where workers are 6 ft or higher above dangerous equipment, a guardrail, safety net or personal fall arrest system is in place.	☐	☐	☐	

SECTION C | Roofs and leading edges						
No.	**Check item**	**What to look for**	**OK**	**Defect**	**N/A**	**Notes**
16	Low-slope roof edges Ref. 1926.501(b)(10)	Roof edges 6 ft or higher have guardrails, a net or personal fall arrest, or a warning line combined with guardrail, net, fall arrest or a safety monitor.	☐	☐	☐	
17	Safety monitor without warning line Ref. 1926.501(b)(10)	A safety monitor is used alone only on a low-slope roof 50 ft (15.25 m) or less in width.	☐	☐	☐	
18	Steep roof edges Ref. 1926.501(b)(11)	Steep roofs have guardrails with toeboards or a safety net, or workers are using personal fall arrest.	☐	☐	☐	
19	Leading edge crew Ref. 1926.501(b)(2)(i)	Workers building a leading edge 6 ft or higher use a guardrail, net or personal fall arrest system. A § 1926.502(k) plan is used instead only where the employer can demonstrate that these systems are infeasible or that using them creates a greater hazard.	☐	☐	☐	
20	Others near leading edges Ref. 1926.501(b)(2)(ii)	Workers on a surface 6 ft or more above a lower level who are not doing the leading edge work have a guardrail, safety net or personal fall arrest system. A control line stands in for a guardrail only where a guardrail system was chosen, a controlled access zone has already been established for the leading edge work, and only along the edge that parallels the leading edge.	☐	☐	☐	

General guidance only, not legal advice. Check the current regulation and your employer's procedures.

SECTION D | Residential, precast, formwork and bricklaying						
No.	**Check item**	**What to look for**	**OK**	**Defect**	**N/A**	**Notes**
21	Residential construction Ref. 1926.501(b)(13)	Workers at 6 ft or higher have guardrails, safety nets or personal fall arrest, or another measure that paragraph (b) allows. A § 1926.502(k) plan is acceptable only if the employer has shown the listed systems to be infeasible or more dangerous for this work; the employer carries that burden.	☐	☐	☐	
22	Precast concrete erection Ref. 1926.501(b)(12)	Workers erecting or grouting precast members at 6 ft or higher are protected by guardrail systems, safety nets or fall arrest, or by an alternative that paragraph (b) allows. A § 1926.502(k) plan replaces them only where the employer shows that using them is not feasible or would be more hazardous.	☐	☐	☐	
23	Formwork and reinforcing steel Ref. 1926.501(b)(5)	Workers on the face of formwork or rebar with a drop of 6 ft or more use personal fall arrest, a safety net or a positioning device system.	☐	☐	☐	
24	Overhand bricklaying Ref. 1926.501(b)(9)(i)	Bricklayers at 6 ft or higher are protected by a guardrail, net or fall arrest system, or are working in a controlled access zone.	☐	☐	☐	
25	Reaching below the work surface Ref. 1926.501(b)(9)(ii)	Anyone reaching more than 10 in (25 cm) below their working surface has a guardrail, safety net or personal fall arrest system.	☐	☐	☐	

SECTION E | Falling objects						
No.	**Check item**	**What to look for**	**OK**	**Defect**	**N/A**	**Notes**
26	Hard hats Ref. 1926.501(c)	Every employee exposed to falling objects is wearing a hard hat, and one of the measures below is in place.	☐	☐	☐	
27	Toeboards, screens or guardrails Ref. 1926.501(c)(1)	If this option is used, toeboards, screens or guardrails at the higher level stop objects from falling.	☐	☐	☐	
28	Canopy Ref. 1926.501(c)(2)	If this option is used, a canopy structure is in place and materials above are kept far enough from the edge that they would not go over if knocked.	☐	☐	☐	
29	Barricaded drop zone Ref. 1926.501(c)(3)	If this option is used, the drop zone is barricaded, no one enters it, and materials above are kept back from the edge.	☐	☐	☐	

DEFECTS FOUND AND ACTION TAKEN

Item no.	Defect description	Reported to	Action taken / date closed

SIGN-OFF

SAFE TO OPERATE?	☐ Yes ☐ No: tagged out of service	
INSPECTOR SIGNATURE		DATE / TIME
SUPERVISOR REVIEW		DATE / TIME